"With Sukanta Majumdar (the state BJP chief) caught up in his seat (Balurghat), Suvenduda has assumed charge. This has not gone down well with others," says a BJP leader. Besides corruption, the Sandeshkhali controversy and gender insecurity are big themes for the BJP.

In 2019, the BJP won six out of the 10 LS seats reserved for SCs and both the seats—Jhargram and Alipurduars—reserved for Scheduled Tribes (ST). But in 2021, the TMC had clawed back in many of those assembly segments, and the BJP is looking to re-consolidate. It also has to strain itself to retain the Bankura, Bishnupur, Jhargram, Medinipur and Purulia seats. These were won on the back of support from the Kurmis. But the OBC community is unhappy over its unmet demand for ST status. This mirrors the slight disenchantment with the BJP among the Rajbongshis of the north—the five or so seats this SC community influenced votes in the first two phases. After en masse support for saffron in 2019, they now lament lack of movement on the demand for a separate state. The Kurmi-dominated seats in the west vote in the sixth phase, on May 25.

THE TMC FEELS HOT-BUTTON ISSUES LIKE CAA AND UCC WOULD RUB OUT CHANCES OF A DIVISION OF MUSLIM VOTES. THE BJP DISAGREES

Gender forms a more clear-cut frontier to breach. Mamata has till now commanded staunch support from women voters—from 47 per cent of the 37.3 million female votes in 2019, TMC's takehome jumped to 50 per cent in 2021. This is why the Sandeshkhali incident, where women rose up in protest against what they called systematic sexual violence and land-grabbing by local TMC strongman Shahjahan Sheikh and his henchmen, is one of the BJP's biggest weapons. Rekha Patra, a protestor, has been fielded as a BJP candidate from Basirhat, and PM Modi and Bengal BJP leaders never fail to point at Sandeshkhali as an example of "atrocities committed under the TMC".

Congress-Left Combine

And what of the INDIA bloc in Bengal, and its forlorn standard-bearers: the Congress and the Left, who have fielded common candidates? A special Mamata snub was reserved for INDIA, flowing from her conviction that she stood a better chance of adding on to the TMC's 2019 tally of 22 if she went alone. Having another Opposition front in the mix could even help split the anti-incumbency vote. The Left combine of the CPI(Marxist), CPI, RSP and Forward Bloc have put up 30 candidates, while the Congress has fielded 12. The Congress has two MPs from Bengal—Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury from Baharampur and Abu Hasem Khan Choudhury from Malda Dakshin—while the Left has none. However, since 2021, with an influx of young members, the CPI(M) has regained some of its lost ground. Its internal survey shows it can fare well in the Dumdum, Krishnanagar, Jadavpur and Murshidabad seats. "In 2019 and 2021, a major chunk of the Left votes was wrested by the BJP; in case some of that comes back, it will hurt the BJP," says Subhamoy Maitra, professor, Indian Statistical Institute.

For voters, an election free from poll violence is paramount. Violence was reported from Coochbehar during the first phase on April 19, whereas the second phase on April 26 was largely peaceful. The deployment of 30,000 central forces does offer protection, but the spectre of post-poll violence remains.

Ultimately, to do better this time, Mamata must deflect the sharpened barbs of her main adversary and hit targets with her own, well-chosen arrows. Bengal's voters have a lot to chew on. ■



A CURIOUS SIGHT GREETED PEOPLE AT THE JOINT CONGRESS-CPI(M) rally in Baharampur, in Murshidabad district, on April 18. Supporters were struck by Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury—the Bengal Congress chief who is seeking to be elected from the Baharampur constituency, which he has been winning since 1999, for a sixth time—with a scarf printed with CPI(M) symbols around his neck. The Congress and the Left are strange bedfellows, but this is the new political reality in Bengal where Mamata Banerjee's TMC, though part of the INDIA alliance, has decided to contest alone. And Chowdhury, who opposed a seat sharing deal with the TMC, has been among Mamata's worst critics. Standing beside him was